

Louis Kahn: A giant departs

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

When Louis Kahn died a few days ago, the *Globe's* obituary was six words long. Even the *New York Times*, which called Kahn the "foremost American architect" in its headline carried that on Page 46.

Whatever conclusions you care to draw about the visibility of architects in our society, the fact remains that Kahn was undoubtedly the most original and influential American architect of his time, the generator and object, in his last years, of a personality cult that spread his admirers and disciples throughout the world.

His merits will be debated, but his historical importance is secure. Like many architects, Kahn never got any important work to do until he was 50. And he was nearer 60 when he designed his first characteristically Kahn-like building, the Richards Medical Laboratories at the University of Pennsylvania, a building that soon came to be regarded as something of a watershed in 20th century architecture.

Richards Labs appeared at a critical moment, when a lot of architects—lagging behind the general public—were at last beginning to question the almost liturgically dogmatic ideals of modern architecture. To skeptics, these ideals seemed to produce primarily sleek, mechanistic, inhuman buildings, like the anonymous office boxes and apartment slabs that clearly implied, by their repetitive form, that the occupants too were interchangeable.

A reaction had already begun to set in, but it had not found a direction. Some architects, like the late Eero Saarinen, were retreating into a kind of personal sculpture, too whimsical to mean much, like his bird-shaped TWA terminal at Kennedy Airport. Others, like Philip Johnson, seemed to be busily making their buildings look like plastic copies of Greek temples (Lincoln Center is a sad example).

Coming at this confused time, Kahn's Richards Labs and his later works seemed to offer a new di-

rection, achieving the formal richness that the modern movement had lacked, but without either copying historic forms or retreating into personal whimsy. He did this by combining a frank and bold interest in geometry with a rigorous method of sorting out all the different parts of a building and expressing each one clearly and separately, often in a family-like cluster of shapes.

Thus at Richards, the laboratory spaces themselves are basically glass boxes, in typical modernist fashion, but all the stairs, toilets, elevators and duct work are pulled out into brick towers which, interspersed among the glass labs, create a rich yet perfectly logical visual composition. In the anthropomorphic language he always, revealingly, used when talking about buildings, Kahn called the towers "servants" and the glass labs "served spaces."

With this, and later buildings, Kahn legitimized the idea of formal experimentation for a generation of architects who had been mesmerized by the shibboleth that "form follows function." Many of these followers ignored

Kahn's logic while adopting only his interest in geometric games-playing, and diagonal floor plans, circular cut-outs and other devices quickly became fads.

But even as it loosed these liberating winds, Kahn's own work was becoming ever more rigorously logical, maybe too much so, culminating in the astonishingly bold and uncompromising works of his last years such as the national capitol complex at Dacca, Bangladesh, where the clustered buildings sit on the plain like big cubes and cylinders, with cut-outs like eyes and mouths, looking like giant, silent presences from another planet, as permanent, as unblinking as Sphinxes.

Kahn could create horrors — the Bryn Mawr dormitories always seemed to me to fall into this category — and his self-obsessed, mystical, Great Artist attitudes seemed to many people silly at a time when the main thing that 20th Century architecture had proved was that it couldn't yet design a livable environment.

But that certainly wasn't Kahn's fault. He deserved the *Time's* encomium. He was the foremost living American architect.